Challenge Stigma / Find Peace

FrontlineFolks | Guide #25

Secondary Trauma in Partners and Teams

A Field Guide for Frontline Folks and Their Families

Field notes for the pattern in this chapter.

By Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW
Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Disclaimer

This guide is for general education only.

It is not:

- Therapy
- Medical care
- A crisis service
- Individualized advice

Reading this guide does not create a therapist–client relationship with the author or with Never Forgotten Services, PLLC.

If you are in crisis or thinking about harming yourself or someone else, call 988 in the United States, go to your nearest emergency room, or contact your local emergency services.

If you want mental health treatment, please contact a licensed provider in your state or call the number on the back of your insurance card.

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1. What Is Happening

Your partner doesn't work on the frontline, but they absorb your trauma anyway. They hear your stories, hold your stress, and their nervous system starts responding to the threat you bring home. This is secondary trauma (or vicarious trauma): your partner develops stress symptoms not from direct exposure, but from prolonged exposure to you, your dysregulation, and your stories. They might get hypervigilant, develop anxiety, lose sleep, or become emotionally numb. Most partners don't realize they're traumatized until they notice they're reacting to normal situations as if they're dangerous.

Common signs of secondary trauma in partners

- Hypervigilance: Staying alert to your mood, your stress level, waiting for the next 'bad call.'
- Anxiety: Worry that something will happen to you at work, that you'll be hurt, that the problems will get worse.
- Sleep disruption: Trouble sleeping because they're monitoring you, or sleeping lightly ready to respond.
- Emotional numbness: Shutting down connection to protect themselves from absorbing more stress.
- Anger and resentment: Building because they're carrying load that isn't theirs.
- Isolation: Withdrawing from friends or family to avoid explaining or triggering their own stress.
- Intrusive thoughts: About worst-case scenarios involving your work.

> **This is not their failure:**
> Partners develop secondary trauma because they love you and are exposed to you repeatedly. It's a sign of connection, not weakness.

2. Why It Escalates

Frontline folks often talk about calls, share stories seeking support, and bring home activation without explanation. Partners listen, try to help, and absorb the stress. Over time, if there's no clear processing or recovery, partners' nervous systems begin to mirror yours: they get triggered by similar themes, develop protective avoidance behaviors, and start scanning for threats in your environment too.

How secondary trauma escalates

- Repeated story-sharing without processing: Hearing traumatic details without closure leaves them stuck processing the story too.
- Hypervigilance mirroring: You're hypervigilant at home, they become hypervigilant trying to manage you.
- Unexplained mood shifts: You come home activated but don't explain it; partner assumes it's about them and internalizes the blame.
- Lack of downshift: You never decompress, so they never get a 'safe' partner to return to.
- No boundary between work and home: Work trauma bleeds into all family time without containment.
- Partner isolation: They can't talk to anyone about what they're experiencing because it's 'your private stuff.'

> *Why this works: reducing total load and increasing predictability lowers baseline arousal and improves regulation.*

3. What To Do This Week

You can't prevent your partner from absorbing some stress, but you can be intentional about what you share, how you decompress, and how you protect them from becoming your emotional dumping ground.

1. Use the 10-minute decompression ritual before home entry: You decompress alone (car, walk, shower); they get a regulated you, not activated you.
2. Distinguish between 'I need to be heard' and 'I'm using you as therapy': If it's the latter, get a therapist. Partners aren't substitutes for professional processing.
3. Use selective story-sharing: Share enough they understand your stress, not graphic details that create intrusive thoughts. 'Rough day' is sometimes enough.
4. Explicitly tell them the 'ending' of hard stories: 'It was scary, but protocol worked, I'm safe, situation resolved.' Without closure, they worry endlessly.
5. Create a 'work talk' window: Dedicated 15 minutes where you can debrief, then it's off-limits. Contain it instead of bleeding it all day.
6. Check in on their secondary trauma: 'How's this affecting you? What do you need from me?' Give them permission to have feelings too.

> Field rule: set the bar low enough to do it even on your worst day.

4. For Partners and Team

Stress communication should be clear, brief, and repeatable. Predictable routines protect relationships.

- Use concrete language when explaining your stress: 'I'm activated from the shift, I need an hour alone' not vague withdrawn silence.
- Agree on pause and return-time rules: If they're feeling secondary trauma, honor their need for a break from heavy conversations.
- Debrief after hard moments without blame: 'That story hit differently; let's talk about how to handle that kind of sharing moving forward.'
- Predictable communication beats perfect communication: Consistent, bounded communication is better than occasional deep but uncontained venting.

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5. When To Get More Help

Self-guided tools are a start. Escalate care when symptoms persist, spread, or begin harming safety and function.

- Your partner's symptoms are not improving despite your efforts to decompress.
- They're isolating more or showing clear anxiety symptoms.
- They're becoming reactive or resentful about your job.
- Kids are noticing and reacting to their parent's secondary trauma.
- Structured couples or family support (trauma-informed couples therapy, partner support groups) can help both of you process without rupture.

6. 7-Day Field Drill

Use the worksheet every day for one week. Track trigger, body signal, and reset action. Keep what works and remove what does not.

> **Daily drill:**
> 1) Name the trigger.
> 2) Name the first body signal.
> 3) Run one reset action.
> 4) Log response quality.

Worksheet 1: Worksheet: Secondary Trauma in Partners and Teams

Use this to track the pattern in this chapter and build a practical response you can repeat under load.

Where did this pattern show up this week?

List specific moments at work, at home, and in transition.

What did it cost you when it took over?

Name impact on body, mood, decisions, and relationships.

What two actions will you run for the next 7 days?

Choose actions small enough to use on hard days.

1. Trigger:

What activated the pattern?

2. Early body signal:

What did your body do first?

3. Reset action used:

What fast action lowered intensity?

4. Better next response:

What exact behavior will you use next time?

> Track this daily for one week, then tighten the plan around what actually worked.

Worksheet 2: Worksheet: Secondary Trauma in Partners and Teams - Partner/Team Check-In

Use this page for one short practical check-in each week.

What do others notice first when this pattern is active?

Capture observable behavior, not labels.

What support helps most and least?

List what helps and what escalates the issue.

What agreement will you both practice this week?

One clear action from each side.

1. Signal phrase:

What phrase means pause and reset?

2. Time-to-return commitment:

When will re-engagement happen?

3. Repair step:

What specific repair happens after a rupture?

> Keep check-ins short, specific, and repeatable.

Closing

You've seen and carried more than most people will ever know.

Blow ups and shutdowns are not proof that you're broken or that your relationship is doomed.

They are signs that your nervous system has been running in survival mode for a long time.

The fact that you picked up this guide and read it matters.

You are choosing to be intentional about how you show up for the people who matter to you.

That choice is a lot more powerful than having flawless days.

About the Author

Michael Jenkins, MS, MSW, LCSW

Founder, Never Forgotten Services, PLLC

Michael is a U.S. Army combat veteran and licensed clinical social worker who specializes in working with military, veterans, and first responders—our frontline folks. After leaving the military, he spent years fighting his own demons and trying to figure out why he could hold it together on the job but feel completely wrecked at home. The turning point was realizing he wasn't the only one living that split life—and that nobody should have to feel that alone, confused, or broken by what the job asks of them.

Since then, his work has focused on trauma, the impact of high-stress jobs on home life, and helping families make sense of what the job brings home. He uses plain language, zero shame, and a "you're not crazy, this actually makes sense" approach to help frontline folks and their families understand what's happening in their nervous systems and learn how to move through the chaos together.